

Reimagining Cooperation in a Fragmented World

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The World Economic Forum (WEF) conducted its 53rd annual meeting, with the theme, "Cooperation in a Fragmented World," highlighting the need for cooperation and inclusive world development ideas with the key to bridge social, political, and economic development by leaving no one behind. These key ideas underline the imperative on the global leadership of togetherness to build sustainable and resilient systems and address the crucial and rising world challenges.

As a part of the same wagon, India has exhibited in multiple international forums, the need for collective action. This is being largely undertaken under the G20 presidency for India in 2023, wherein "Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam" has been identified as the key working theme for the India's presidency tenure. "One Earth, One Family, One Future", presents the impeccable bounty of a collective society, something that holds very dear to the cultural fabric of the nation and building it as an opportunity to bring the fragmented world closer.

In WEF's annual meeting, over 2700 business and political leaders from around 130 countries have come together to restore international cooperation in a situation wherein the countries are prioritizing national interests in purview of the Covid 19 struggle and Russian aggression towards Ukraine.

We are witnessing manifold economic, political, and social forces creating fragmentation at the national and global level. The WEF's agenda calls for addressal of the "trust deficit" and its fundamental cause, in a pledge to reinforce cooperation amongst the business, civil society, and government for durable recovery and adaptable future which is inclusive and addresses the challenges of climate change.

In recent years, some of the biggest issues facing our world have been hostilities, climate change, displacement, unemployment, and increasing religious or regional polarisation. There are more refugee settlements with displaced people than ever before. The recent UNHCR report mentions that there are more than 100 million refugees, which makes over 1% of the world's population. While on the other hand, the world is still recovering from the Covid 19 crisis, with the uncertainty of different incoming variants and the lack of its containment in China.

Further, the economic situation is undergoing the perils of struggle and on verge of recession, heightened by the war. According to the International Monetary Fund (IMF), around one third of the world is expected to hit recession this year. Geo-political situation is quite complex with the Russia-Ukraine War, India-China, America-China, Iran-America etc. conflicts. These facts are evidence of the world facing a lot of difficulties and that its fragmentation has really weakened our ability to work together and tackle problems that we all face collectively.

India, being a crucial player strategically, through its various opportunities with a strong Global South footing supplemented by the G20 Presidency along with multilateral organisations stakeholdership such as SAARC, BRICS & QUAD, has an advantage to fill this void.

Recognizing these, India's G20 presidency is outlined towards promoting growth, remapping development plans, and achieving the Sustainable Development Goal's targets (SDG). It calls for Stronger Recovery and Resilience in Development Countries, Least Developed Countries (LDCs) and SIDs. The G- 20 principle is to Scale up Blended Finance Vision Statement: Multilateralism for Sustainable Development Goals.

> ***"Turbulent times can energize actors and ideas that can lead to new and better modes of cooperation"***
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This stagflation with the ongoing backdrop of weak growth and high inflation means that the policymakers are facing difficult choices. Taming inflation together with ensuring growth is one of the foremost challenges for western economies.

In this fragmented world, multilateral associations play an important role in driving connections and breaking down barriers. It can bring world's businesses and governments together and help them collaborate by creating a robust ecosystem for economic activities and innovations. The relevance of Multilateralism has become far more than ever, as the need of the hour is to put together all the brilliant ideas from the most ignited minds across the globe and turn them into action in purview of human development. In all of this, India is at a key position and in all possibilities, it looks like that it will emerge as a Beacon Light Leader.

Nations have to think seriously to reduce cross border tensions, cut budget on armaments and defence and redirect resources towards health, education, skilling, innovation, and infrastructure as western economies are already overheated by phenomenal rise in interest rates. The solution lies in having peace with prosperity in these turbulent times and fragmented world.

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